

D.J. PARIS

ONE BUSINESS DAY. THAT'S THE LAW.

That's how long Illinois gives you to get earnest money into the trust account.

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**A CHECK IN YOUR
DESK DRAWER IS A
LICENSE PROBLEM,
NOT A PAPERWORK
PROBLEM.**

Earnest money that hasn't hit the trust account isn't
"getting to it later." It's already late.

ILLINOIS DOESN'T GIVE A GRACE PERIOD. IT GIVES YOU ONE BUSINESS DAY.

Under Illinois Administrative Code title 68, section 1450.750(d)(1), a sponsoring broker must place earnest money into the trust account no later than the next business day after the contract is signed or the money is received. The Illinois Real Estate License Act lists a late deposit as its own separate ground for discipline, under 225 ILCS 454, section 20-20(a)(17), apart from any dispute over the deal itself. The deadline isn't a guideline agents interpret. It's a specific number of days, and it starts the moment you take the check.

FIX THE HABIT, NOT THE MEMORY:

- 1 Put the deposit deadline on the calendar the same hour you take the check.**

An all-day event with the file name on it, not a mental note.

- 2 Deposit before you leave the office that day, not "this week."**

The rule counts business days, and a busy Friday still counts as one.

- 3 Ask your managing broker where the trust account log lives, if you don't already know.**

If you can't answer that today, that's the actual gap.

THE TAKEAWAY

**THE EARNEST
MONEY CHECK
ISN'T YOURS TO
HOLD ONTO.
ILLINOIS ALREADY
TOLD YOU HOW
LONG YOU HAVE.**